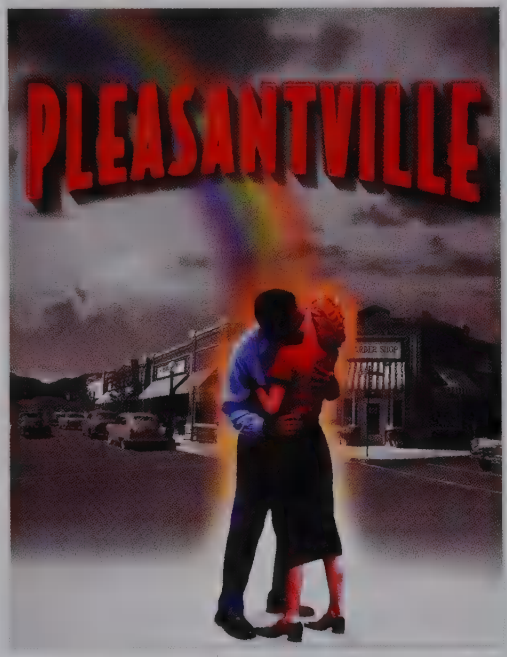
the hero's surname is Darcy in both stories. In case anyone missed the point, Colin Firth, who had played Mr Darcy in the 1995 BBC mini-series of *Pride and Prejudice*, was cast as Mark Darcy in the film.

How films are promoted: film posters

Film posters: giving information

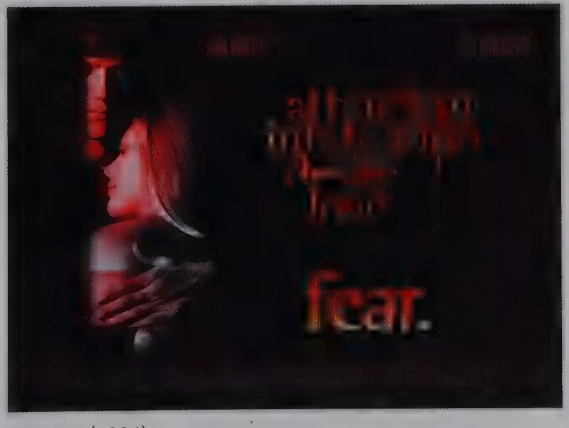
Film posters are hard to ignore – they are large, they are eye-catching and they are often intriguing. How well do they communicate information about the genre, characters and events in the films? Look at posters **8** to **11**, showing films featuring movie star Reese Witherspoon. What genre would you expect each film to be? In what different ways is Reese Witherspoon presented in these posters?



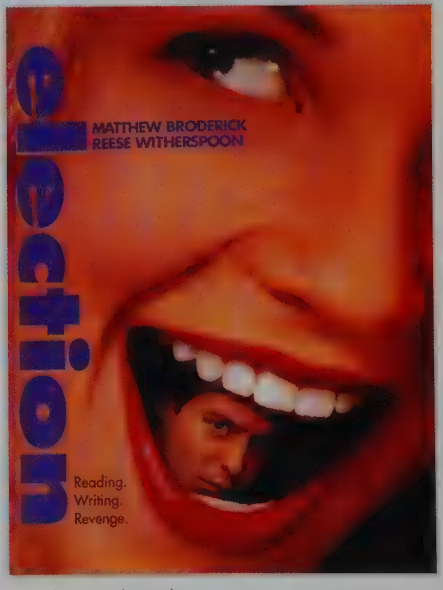
8 *Pleasantville* (1998)



9 *The Importance of Being Earnest* (2002)



10 *Fear* (1996)



11 *Election* (1999)

ACTIVITY 15

In pairs, use the information on the posters, both in words and pictures, to match these plot summaries to the film titles in posters **8** to **11**.

A Nicole discovers that her 'perfect' boyfriend David has a violent and disturbed side to his character.

B Jennifer and her brother David find themselves trapped in his favourite 1950s soap opera.

C This screen version of Oscar Wilde's play casts Reese as the young sweetheart Cecily in a comedy of manners.

D Tracy wants to be student president and uses some surprising tactics in this comedy film about the world of high-school politics.

Did you find lots of clues on the posters? Posters communicate information by the way the images are presented. The **gesture codes** of the characters instantly signal violent and disturbing events or romantic and comic moments. Other details, such as costume, location and lighting, also help us read the poster's messages.

A key message is the genre of the film. Next, the poster gives clues about the story in the **tag line**. Tag lines can become well known in their own right:

- The science fiction/horror classic *Alien* (1979) had the famous tag line *In space, no one can hear you scream ...*
- *Jaws 2* (1978) had the tag line *Just when you thought it was safe to go back in the water*. This was an intertextual reference to the first film *Jaws* (1975), which had been a huge hit. It reminds the audience of the terror of bathing in shark-infested waters.

ACTIVITY 16

Think of some catchy tag lines for these films:

- *First Victim*: a new monster, part werewolf, part vampire, hits town, looking for his first victim – a teenager.
- *No Way, Baby:* high-school heart-throb Jay is determined not to get tied down in a steady relationship. The high-school babes have other ideas!
- *Triple Deceit*: Detective Pacino is baffled by a series of murders until his new partner gives him some valuable insights. But where does she get her information?

Film posters: promoting stars

One way a poster can grab people's attention is to show pictures of the film's stars. The more popular the star, the more dominant their image will be in the poster. Stars are said to be 'A' or 'B' list depending on how popular they are. Can you identify the biggest **box-office draw** in each of posters **12** to **15**?

KEY TERMS

Box-office draw a performer whose popularity is likely to make a film successful; they are said to *carry* the film

Gesture code how a media text conveys a message using facial expression or body language

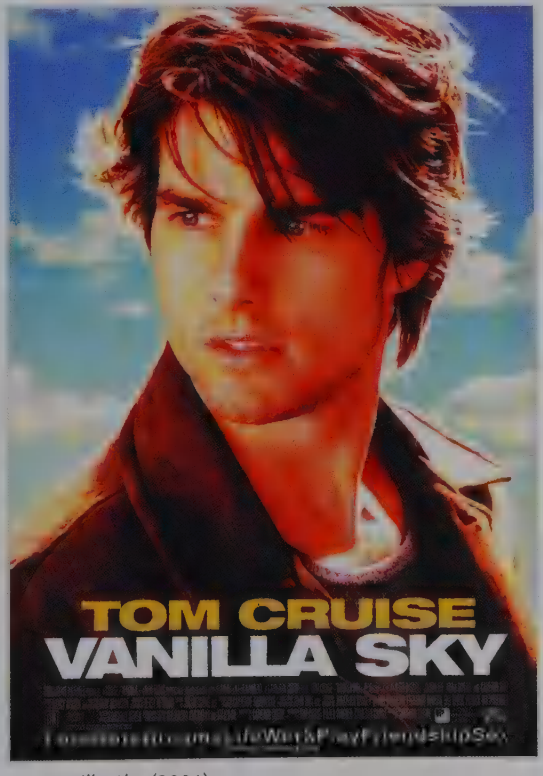
Tag line short, catchy statement on a film poster suggesting the film's content



12 *Pirates of the Caribbean: The Curse of the Black Pearl* (2003)



13 *Titanic* (1997)



14 *Vanilla Sky* (2001)



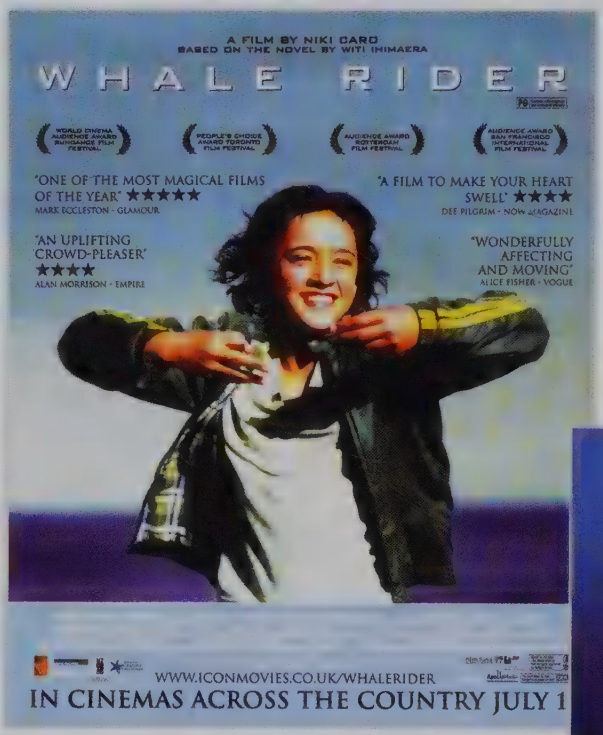
15 *The Hours* (2002)

How could you tell who carried each film? The size and position of the star's name and image are so important that they are part of the star's contract for the film. Big stars try to get their name on the left of the poster and their picture on the right, because these are the most eye-catching positions. Who has these positions in **12**?

Posters are used to publicise and promote a film when it comes out in the cinema. They may be used again when it is available to rent or, a couple of months later, buy on video or DVD.

Film posters: targeting audiences

Film posters target audiences, and audiences in different parts of the world like different sorts of films. They may be particularly interested in a film set in their own country, and people of different cultures may find different types of films, or different features of the same film, appealing. Although the film remains the same, posters may portray it quite differently in different countries.



16 *Whale Rider* poster shown in the UK



17 *Whale Rider* poster shown in the United States

- *Presentation:* How much of the publication is given over to photos? Are any drawings used? How many different styles of print are used? Are the colours bright and brash or muted and subtle?
- *Audience:* What kind of reader are the products aimed at? How do you know?
- *Front pages or covers:* These are a crucial part of any publication. They are the way potential readers are 'grabbed' as they look along the racks in newsagents. What does the front cover tell you about the sort of readership being targeted? What idea of the content of the magazine does the cover give? How does the combination of pictures and words encourage people to buy the publication? What kind of lifestyle is being catered for by this magazine?
- *Advertising:* newspapers and magazines need to sell advertising space to help cover the cost of production. What products are being advertised and what does this tell you about the sorts of readers being targeted?

Production

When you have decided on your target audience, draw up your production schedule. This is a list of all the things which need to be done, who will be doing them and the deadlines which need to be met.

Stage 1: Planning the content

Draw up a list of all the articles you wish to include and how many pages you can realistically produce in the time you have been given. It is much better to produce fewer high-quality pages than a lot of articles which are poorly written and badly laid out because you have tried to do too much in too short a space of time.

As a guideline, think in terms of each individual being responsible for two double-page spreads. The person responsible for the cover could count that as the equivalent of a double page. Anyone designing a full-page advertisement could also substitute that for a double-page spread.

Once you have a clear outline of what the finished product will look like, divide up the writing and photography tasks among the members of your group.

Stage 2: Writing the articles

You might be able to write some articles immediately, but others will need to be researched or require an interview to be arranged. You might decide at this stage that one of the group will act as a picture researcher. Their job will be to search the Internet and collect a range of pictures which might be useful for each article so that a wide choice is available at the page design stage.

Ideally you will have two *production meetings* where the whole group come together and review the work.

The first one should be halfway through the writing stage. The main purpose will be to check that everyone is running to time, and if not, take immediate action to make sure any problems are overcome. Are you able to extend your deadlines? If not, are you going to have to drop some articles? Will there be sufficient content left to ensure each group member can show how much they know about producing whatever product you have chosen to make? Are the pictures that have been collected appropriate?

The second production meeting will come at the end of the process of writing. You should all read each other's work in a productive, critical way and suggest any

amendments which might be necessary. At this stage you should make a mock-up of the front page or cover and decide on a title for the paper or magazine. Anyone who has been designing a full-page advert should present their ideas at this meeting. Finally, you need to list any photographs that need to be taken.

Stage 3: Photo shoots

The photograph for the front cover of a magazine should be very carefully planned. Photographs used in advertisements also need to be thought through and a variety of alternatives taken from which the best one can be chosen.

For a professional fashion/advertisement shoot there will be a number of people involved:

- art director (in overall charge of the shoot)
- photographer (takes the photos and makes suggestions to the art director)
- two or three photographer's assistants to carry gear and set up lights
- stylist (to supervise costume and make-up)
- the client or their representative (to check they are happy with what is being photographed)
- the model or models.

You will probably have a much smaller crew, but you should certainly involve more than one person. Above all you need to look at every single detail of the images that you take to make sure that the photograph is conveying exactly the right message to your audience.

When posing any models for each photograph, use the following checklist:

- *Posture:* how will I pose the model? Lazing on a sofa will give a relaxed feel to the image; sitting upright in an office chair will give a more formal feel.
- *Facial expression:* do I want to create a moody look? Or do I want a happy, relaxed feel to the shot?
- *Costume:* what someone wears tells other people a great deal about them. Make sure that each piece of your model's clothing has been selected to get across the chosen image.
- *Setting and props:* think about the message that the setting of your shot will convey, and any props you use. Is the school playing field *really* the best setting for your jeans advert – or have you just gone there because it is easy? Is your teacher's N-reg. Fiesta going to add to the 'cool image' you are trying to create?

Once you have all of the things on that checklist sorted out, your next job is to compose them within the frame of your camera. Although there is no hard-and-fast set of rules about what makes a good photograph, the following composition guidelines might offer you a starting point for making interesting images.